



The Quote-Request Checklist

Eight questions that turn a vague “how much for a fit-out?” message into a site visit, a quick guide to which Dubai authority is likely to be involved, what a clear quotation should state, and a follow-up rhythm that stops quotes going quiet. Everything here works with tools you already have.

1. Why the first reply matters

Clients asking for a fit-out or renovation quote usually contact several contractors. Estimators are often on site or driving when the message arrives, so replies slip to the evening or the next day. In Harvard Business Review's study of online sales leads, firms that contacted a lead within an hour were nearly seven times as likely to qualify it as firms that waited longer, and the median response time was 42 hours.

Source: J. Oldroyd, K. McElheran, D. Elkington, “The Short Life of Online Sales Leads”, Harvard Business Review, March 2011 — hbr.org/2011/03/the-short-life-of-online-sales-leads

2. The 8-question intake

Ask these in the first reply. Each answer saves a phone call, and together they tell your estimator whether the job fits before anyone drives to site.

#	Ask	Why it matters to the estimator
1	Type of work (office fit-out, retail, villa renovation, kitchen/bathroom, MEP, joinery...)	Routes the lead to the right person and price book.
2	Emirate, area and building / community name	Tells you travel time and which authority and building rules are likely to apply (see section 3).
3	Approximate size (sq ft or sq m) and number of rooms / floors	First rough budget check; filters out jobs that are too small or too big.
4	Current state: shell & core, previous fit-out to strip, or occupied	Changes demolition, disposal and working-hours assumptions.
5	Photos, a short video or the floor plan / layout drawing	Many questions answered without a visit; better first estimate.
6	Target start date and hard deadline (lease start, opening day)	Separates urgent, high-intent jobs from “just looking”.
7	Budget range, if they have one	Lets you propose the right specification first time.
8	Who decides, and the best way and time to reach them	Avoids quoting to someone who cannot approve.

Copy-paste intake message (WhatsApp or email)

Thank you for contacting [Company]! To prepare your quote quickly, please send:

1) type of work, 2) emirate, area and building name, 3) approximate size, 4) is the space empty, previously fitted out or occupied?, 5) photos or a floor plan if you have them, 6) when you would like to start and any deadline, 7) a budget range if you have one, 8) who will approve the work.

We reply within [X] hours and can arrange a site visit once we have these details.

3. Which authority is likely involved? (Dubai quick map)

Clients often ask “do I need a permit?” before they ask for a price. Knowing the likely route early lets you include approvals in the quote or flag them as an exclusion. Typical routes by location:

Location (examples)	Usual fit-out approval route
Mainland Dubai (e.g. Deira, Bur Dubai, Business Bay)	Dubai Municipality, via the Build in Dubai platform
DDA / TECOM zones (e.g. Internet City, Media City, d3, Knowledge Park)	Dubai Development Authority fit-out permit
Trakhees zones (e.g. JAFZA, Palm Jumeirah, Dubai Maritime City)	Trakhees modification NOC via the Dubai Trade portal
DIFC	DIFC property development, alongside building management
DMCC / JLT	DMCC NOC, alongside the building / facilities manager
All zones	Landlord / building management NOC is required in nearly all cases; DEWA and Dubai Civil Defence approvals apply depending on the scope of work

Summary based on Mitchells Commercial Realty, “Dubai Commercial Fit-Out Permits: Which Authority?” (mitchellscommercialrealty.com/guides/fitout-permits). Rules, fees and timelines change and depend on scope: always confirm with the building management and the authority’s own portal before quoting approval work. This is general information, not legal or regulatory advice.

4. What a clear quotation states

Most quotes are lost to silence, and many of the rest to confusion. A quote the client can forward to their manager without calling you back should state:

- [] Scope in plain words, room by room or trade by trade, with the drawing or site-visit date it is based on.
- [] Line items with quantities and unit prices, the subtotal, **VAT at 5% shown separately**, and the total including VAT.
- [] What is excluded: authority fees and NOCs (unless included), furniture, IT, landlord charges, out-of-hours work premiums.
- [] Programme: expected start, duration and the assumptions it depends on (approvals, access, client decisions).
- [] Payment milestones and the quote's validity period.
- [] Your trade licence name, address and Tax Registration Number, matching what will appear on the tax invoice.

A quotation is not a tax invoice. Once work is invoiced, the UAE Federal Tax Authority requires a tax invoice to carry, among other things: the words “Tax Invoice”, the supplier's name, address and TRN, a sequential invoice number and date, the date of supply, item descriptions with quantity and unit price, the VAT rate and VAT amount in AED, and the gross total. The standard VAT rate is 5%.

Source: Wafeq, “VAT Invoice Requirements in UAE” (wafeq.com/en-ae/tax-and-reporting/vat-invoice-requirements-in-uae), summarising Article 59 of the VAT Executive Regulation. Confirm your own obligations with your tax adviser.

5. The quote follow-up rhythm

When	What to send	Status after
Within minutes (or away message)	Thank them and send the 8-question intake	New request
Same day	Offer two site-visit slots, or a rough range if photos are enough	Visit booked / Waiting

When	What to send	Status after
Within the time you promised	Send the quote with a one-line summary of scope, total incl. VAT and start date	Quote sent
2 working days after quote	"Did the quote cover everything you needed? Happy to walk through it."	Quote sent
7 days after quote	Ask one question: timing, budget or scope. Offer to adjust.	Negotiation / Lost
On loss	Ask why, politely, once. Record the reason.	Lost (reason noted)

Only message people who contacted you first, and stop as soon as someone asks you to. Under the UAE Personal Data Protection Law (Federal Decree-Law No. 45 of 2021), personal data generally should not be processed without the owner's consent, and people can ask for their data to be corrected or for processing to stop (u.ae/en/about-the-uae/digital-uae/data/data-protection-laws).

6. The weekly scorecard (6 numbers)

Number	How to count it	This week
Quote requests	New WhatsApp, email, phone and website enquiries	
Median first-reply time	Middle value of the times from message to first real answer	
Out-of-hours requests	Arrived evenings, Fridays or holidays	
Site visits booked	From this week's requests	
Quotes sent / value (AED)	Count and total incl. VAT	
Jobs won / value (AED)	Signed or deposit received	

If first-reply time is over an hour, or a large share of requests arrive out of hours, that is where automation pays for itself first.

7. See it working on your own enquiries

Mountain AI builds a WhatsApp enquiry assistant for fit-out and contracting firms. It replies straight away in English or Arabic, asks the intake questions above, collects photos and hands your estimator a lead that is ready for a site visit. It only gives answers you approve, and passes anything unclear to your team.

Free demo in 24 hours, set up with your company's services and areas → **14-day pilot, AED 1,500**, credited in full if you continue → **full setup AED 7,500 + AED 1,250/month**.

Try the contractor demo: mountainai-ae.com/demo/fitout-contractor-assistant.html

Request your free demo: WhatsApp +971 56 777 3366 (send "DEMO") · info@mountainai-ae.com · mountainai-ae.com/contracting.html